Feedback tasks

Planning time to act on feedback

Use feedback tasks to make improvement an act of thinking. Select a solvable challenge that helps students locate, explain and repair an issue rather than simply copy a correction.

How to do it well

1 Choose a narrow learning focus. Identify the knowledge, skill or misconception that matters and that pupils can realistically improve.

2 Record what needs fixing without annotating it. Mark or review the work, then state the number and type of issues rather than correcting each location.

3 Pose a solvable search. Tell pupils what they are looking for and what success will look like, but leave the locating and correcting to them.

4 Add the minimum cue if needed. Narrow the section, paragraph, step or error type without revealing the exact line or answer.

5 Protect in-class time to act. Return the work when pupils have time to search, think, revise and use relevant models or criteria.

6 Close the loop. Ask pupils to explain what they changed and why, check the correction and later test whether they can apply the learning independently.

What this sounds like

“Two statements misuse the key term. Find them, explain the issue and correct them using the definition and the model.”

Classroom example. In Languages, the teacher identifies the number and type of errors in a familiar paragraph without correcting each location. Pupils use the model and criteria to find, explain and repair them. When a pupil lacks the relevant rule, the teacher gives direct teaching rather than leave the student in an unproductive search.

Top tips that make the technique work

Use detective work when pupils can solve it. Give the number and type of issues, then let students find and fix them.

Add the minimum cue. Narrow to a paragraph, step or criterion if the search is too broad.

Give direct teaching where needed. An error caused by missing knowledge is not a productive puzzle.

Protect action time. Plan redrafting, rehearsal, reattempting or re-testing into the lesson rather than hoping students act later.

Require an explanation. Ask what changed and why, then use a related task where the corrected learning matters.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Set a bounded, achievable improvement action.	Cryptic feedback on an error students cannot diagnose.
Keep pupils doing the cognitive work.	Colour-coded corrections with no new thinking.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Feedback as Detective Work | Barton - Correcting in green pen does not work